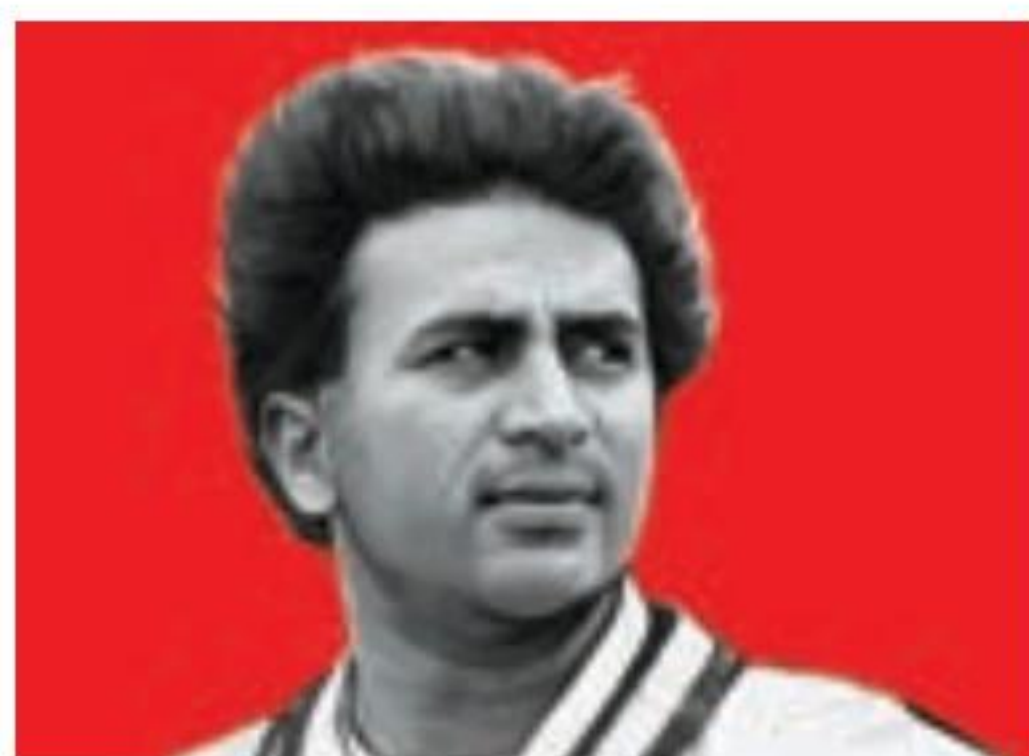




ON THE WRITE LINE

Sunil Gavaskar



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THE HYPOCRISY IS SO BRAZEN THAT IT IS SIMPLY MIND-BOGGLING

It will be interesting to see the report and rating for the Mackay pitch by the match referee. There's generally been a desire among the referees to get **brownie points** from the media of the old powers.

So, another Test match in Australia has finished within two days. This has happened four times there in the last few years. And we are yet to hear any criticism of the trampoline-bounce pitches that produce such results. The excuses will come thick and fast. 'Oh, the groundsman, sorry, turf executive, got it wrong. He went by the weather forecast, which predicted some hot weather, so he left a little more grass, and that led to the excessive bounce.' Or the other cricketing excuse that the batters didn't have the technique to cope with the bounce and it wasn't the fault of the pitch. This last excuse could be faintly accepted if the home team batters had batted well, but when even the home batters can't stitch a run or a decent partnership together, then what does it tell you about the pitch?

The pitch in Mackay was no surprise. After the Aussies were humiliated by the Bangladeshis in the first Test, they were going to prepare a pitch that would be fast and bouncy. And, of course, claim that the groundsman had done it on his own and there were zero instructions from the team management. We all know what really happens. It's just that the Indian management is open about wanting pitches to suit its bowling strength while those from the old powers will do the little whispering and nudging and get a surface that they need.

Bangladesh got Test status way back in the

year 2000, but it was only after 23 years that Australia deemed it fit to invite them for a second Test series, and that too at their non-regular Test venues. India also had to wait for 20 years after their inaugural tour in 1947-48 for their second tour in 1967-68 and then another 10 years for the next tour Down Under. Thereafter, tours have been every four or five years, but now, with the TV revenues depending on whether India are touring the country or not, the old powers would love India to tour there every year if possible. That's why there are split tours too, where there's the red-ball series one year and the white-ball limited-overs series the following year. So, in a broadcast rights cycle of four years, there are two India tours, which bumps up the value of their broadcast rights manifold.

It will be interesting to see the report and rating for the Mackay pitch by the match referee. There's generally been a desire among the referees to get brownie points from the media of the old powers. So it won't be a surprise if there's no adverse rating for the Mackay pitch, just as we have seen for similar two-day finishes in recent years. But lo and behold, if a game finishes in three days in India, there will be all kinds of derogatory reports and insinuations made about the pitches, BCCI and Indian cricket. The hypocrisy is so brazen that it is simply mind-boggling. The usual excuse of ineptitude against fast bowling will be brought out. Nobody says the